

Move Over, T. rex -- There's a New King in Town, and It Swam!

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Imagine a sea monster as long as a school bus, with a mouth full of teeth like steak knives. That's Tylosaurus rex the 'king of the knob lizards'! Scientists just discovered this ancient ocean **predator**, and it ruled the seas 80 million years ago. That's 13 million years before T. rex stomped on land. Its **fossils** were hiding in museums for decades, but everyone thought they were a smaller cousin. Then, two sharp-eyed **paleontologists** noticed something was different. Dr. Michael Polcyn saw a weird fossil in Texas. Years later, Dr. Amelia Zietlow spotted another odd one in New York. They checked dozens of **fossils** and found the truth: these were a brand-new **species**! The biggest clue? The teeth. Tylosaurus rex had sharp, **jagged** teeth for slicing **prey**, while its cousin had smooth, cone-shaped teeth for grabbing. Also, the new king was found mostly in Texas, while the cousin lived in Kansas. The coolest fossil is 'The Black Knight' a giant skeleton found near Dallas in 1979. It has a broken jaw that healed, proving this beast was tough enough to survive and keep hunting. So next time you think of ancient monsters, remember: the ocean had its own T. rex, and it was just as scary!

Word Treasure

paleontologists -- Scientists who study old bones and fossils to learn about ancient life.

fossils -- The hardened remains of plants or animals that lived long ago.

species -- A group of living things that are similar and can produce babies together.

jagged -- Having a rough, uneven edge with sharp points.

prey -- An animal that is hunted and eaten by another animal.

predator -- An animal that hunts and eats other animals.

Background you need

Most people think of dinosaurs like T. rex when they hear 'fossils', but many giant reptiles lived in the oceans too.

These sea creatures, called mosasaurs, were the top predators of their time, ruling warm shallow seas that covered parts of North America.

Paleontologists sometimes find fossils in museums that were mislabeled for years, waiting for someone to look more closely.

Break it down

WHO: Two paleontologists, Dr. Michael Polcyn and Dr. Amelia Zietlow.

WHAT: They discovered Tylosaurus rex, a new giant ocean predator as long as a school bus.

WHERE: Mainly in Texas (USA), with a cousin species living in Kansas.

WHY: The fossils were thought to be a smaller cousin until the scientists noticed the jagged teeth and the pattern of being found in Texas.

Why it matters

This discovery shows that even old museum collections can hold secrets -- if you stay curious and observe carefully, you might discover something amazing too.

Test what you remember

1. How long ago did *Tylosaurus rex* rule the seas?
 - (A) 80 million years ago
 - (B) 50 million years ago
 - (C) 13 million years ago
 - (D) 100 million years ago
2. How many years before *Tyrannosaurus rex* did *Tylosaurus rex* live?
 - (A) 13 million years
 - (B) 5 million years
 - (C) 20 million years
 - (D) 80 million years
3. In which state did Dr. Michael Polcyn see a weird fossil?
 - (A) Texas
 - (B) Kansas
 - (C) New York
 - (D) Dallas
4. What was the biggest clue that this was a new species?
 - (A) The teeth were sharp and jagged
 - (B) The fossil was found in a museum
 - (C) The jaw was broken
 - (D) It was bigger than other fossils
5. Where was most of the new species found?
 - (A) Texas
 - (B) Kansas
 - (C) New York
 - (D) Dallas
6. What was special about 'The Black Knight' fossil?
 - (A) It had a broken jaw that healed
 - (B) It was the biggest fossil found
 - (C) It was completely black
 - (D) It was found in Kansas

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Exciting new discovery:** Finding a new top predator shows how much is still unknown about ancient oceans and fills in a missing piece of the dinosaur-age puzzle.
2. **Skeptical view:** Some scientists might want more evidence before agreeing it truly is a separate species, since differences in teeth can sometimes be variations within one species.
3. **Museum check-up:** The story highlights how important it is to re-examine old fossils in museums -- treasures can hide in plain sight for decades.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):